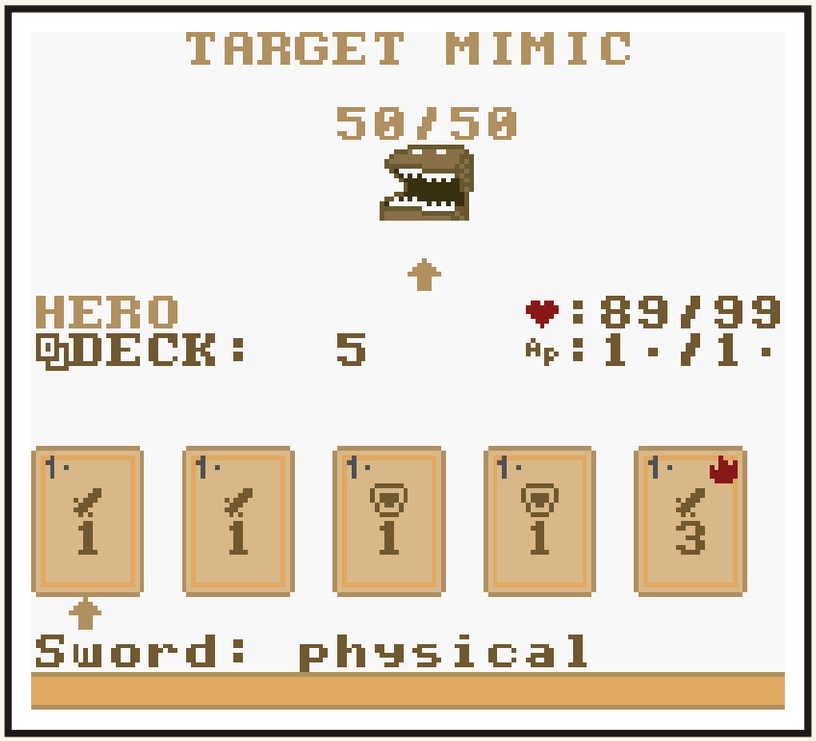
KAARTENHELD

PLAYER'S GUIDE

INSTRUCTION BOOKLET



A card-duelling adventure in five small cards and one big castle.

DMG-GB-EUR

GAME BOY

MADE IN THE GROVE

CONTENTS

1. The Story 2
2. Starting Out 4
3. Controls 6
4. Walking the World 7
5. Your Hero 10
6. Your Cards 12
7. A Battle Begins 17
8. Gold, Shops and Loot 26
9. Gems 28
10. Saving and Loading 32
11. Winning the Demo 33
12. Tips and Tricks 34
13. Quick Reference 35
14. Precautions 36

This game is an early demo. The rules in this book — cards, battles, quests, gems — are real. The specific people, places and numbers are examples from the demo and will grow and change as the land fills in.

1. The Story

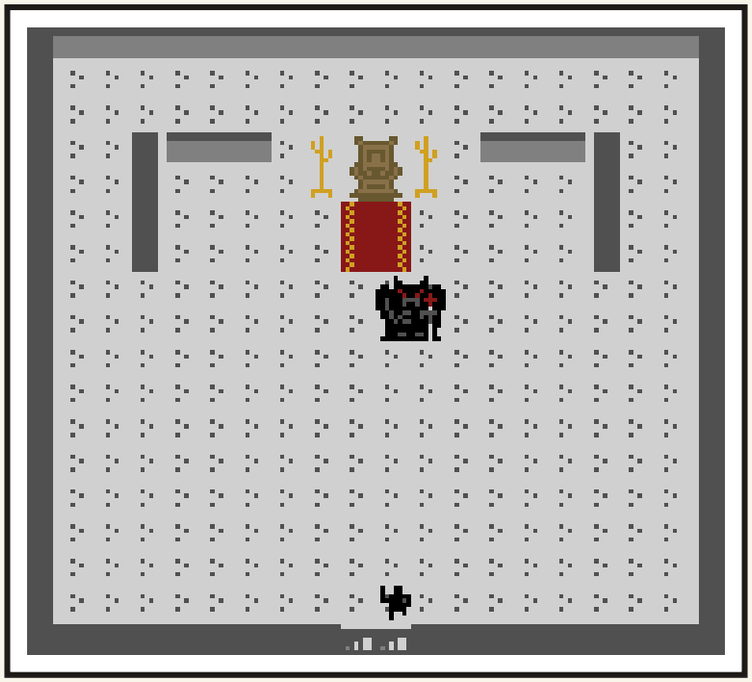
Once the land was quiet. Then the **slimes** came.

They oozed out of the marshes, chewed through the hedgerows, and settled in like they owned the place. Now the roads crawl with bats, spiders and worse, and the settlements have learned to keep their doors shut and their opinions to themselves.

You are the hero who woke up in **Wake Grove** with a handful of cards and no good excuse to stay home. Your cards are your courage: every fight in this land is a card duel, and a well-played hand beats a sharp sword any day of the week.

The folk of the **human settlement** to the east will ask for your help — in this demo, a merchant wants his family heirloom back, and the Mayor wants monsters dealt with. And far to the north, behind the old castle walls, something is waiting in the throne room that has been waiting a very long time.

Its name is the **Lord of Slimes**. That is where the demo's road ends — for now. More of the land, and more of its stories, is still to come.



The throne room at the end of the road

2. Starting Out

Switch on your Game Boy. After the title screen, press **START** and choose from the menu:

Menu	What it does
NEW GAME	Begin a brand-new adventure.
CONTINUE	Load a game you saved earlier.
SOUND: ON/OFF	Turn the music on or off.
TUTORIAL	A short how-to-play lesson.
CREDITS	The people who made this.

> **First time?** Play the **TUTORIAL** slides before you start. Use LEFT and RIGHT to turn the pages and **B** to leave.



The title menu

3. Controls

Button	Walking around	In battle
D-Pad	Walk	Move the hand cursor
A	Talk, read, open	Pick a card
B	Cancel	Undo pick; flee from the menu
START	Open your card screen	Open your card screen
SELECT	Load a saved game	Play the cards you picked

Inside any menu, **UP** and **DOWN** move the pointer, **LEFT** and **RIGHT** change pages, **A** chooses and **B** backs out.

4. Walking the World

The land is a wide map of little squares. Walk to the edge of a map and step on a gate arrow (`>` or `<`) to travel to the next place. Towns have gates; wild places have paths; the castle has a big front door.



A settlement on your travels

Stand in front of a person and press **A** to talk. Some of them have something to say, and some of them have something to *give*.



A guard with something to say

- **Signposts** teach you things. Read every one.
- **Helpers** — a guard, a knight, a healer — share hints.
- **Monsters** wander the wilds. Touch one and a battle begins. There is no running past a slime.



A forest path, a few gates north

5. Your Hero

Your hero is a simple sort:

- **15 health points** (HP) to start. When they are gone, the adventure is over.
- **20 gold** in the purse.
- A **starter deck of 12 cards**.
- **1 energy** (AP) for each decision, attack and defence.

Three things keep the hero going: the **Heal Mage** restores all your HP for free, the **Wizard** saves your progress, and the **monsters** drop cards. Visit them all more often than you think you need to.

Your quests

The **QUEST** tab lists every promise you have made. Quests are how the land asks for help, and the demo holds the first few examples:



The QUEST tab tracks everything you promised

- **A monster hunt.** The Mayor pays for dead monsters — an early example of a hunt quest, and one that teaches the value of a finished promise.
- **A lost heirloom.** The Merchant's family keepsake was stolen by bandits in the northern mountains. Bring it home and his shop opens — an early example of a fetch quest with a real reward.
- **The castle.** Something in the throne room has been waiting a very long time. That is the demo's last promise, and its biggest one. The full game will hold many more.

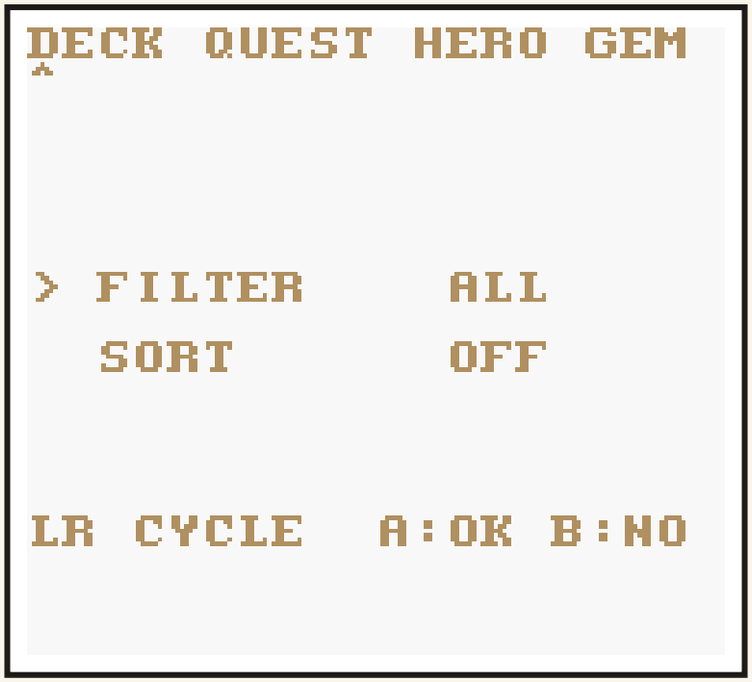
6. Your Cards

Everything you need to win is written on a card. A card shows:

- its **name** and its **material** (wood, bronze, iron, steel or mythril),
- a **type symbol** — `SW`, `SH`, `BO`, `DA` or `RG`,
- a **power** number, used for damage, blocking or healing,
- an **energy cost** (small pips in the corner), and
- sometimes a **rider**: fire, poison or ice.



Your collection and your deck



Sort the list to find a card fast

The five kinds of cards

Card	Attack	Defend
Sword SW	Damage	Nothing
Bow BO	Damage	Nothing
Dagger DA	Damage, may poison	Nothing
Shield SH	0 damage, but counts for combos	**Blocks**
Ring RG	Converts the hand to healing	0 block, but wildcard

> The in-game tutorial calls the ring `HE` for **heal**. It is the same card: `RG` on the card itself, `HE` in the lesson.

Swords, bows and daggers are your attack. A shield deals no damage on your turn — but it still counts as a card when you build a poker hand, which is often worth more than the damage you gave up.

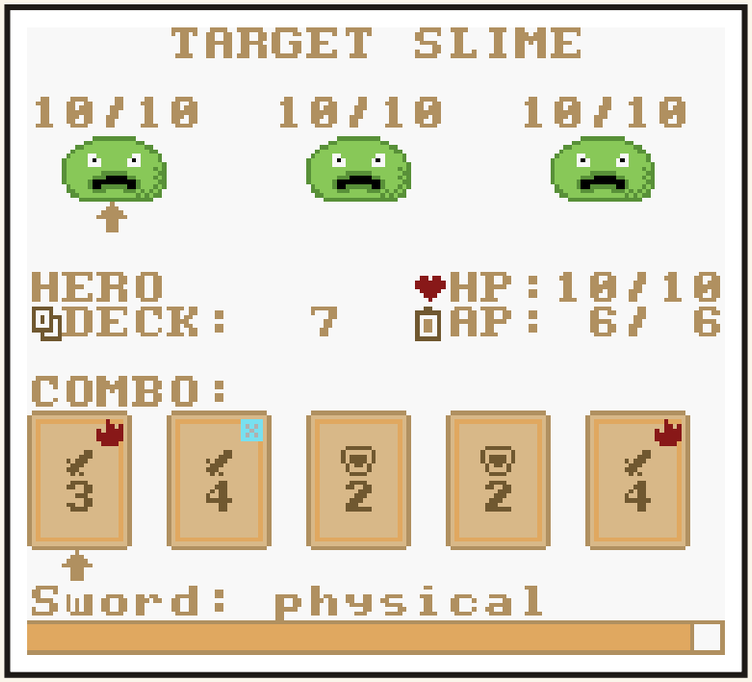
Rings are your healing. They never hurt anybody. Played with an attack, the whole hand turns into a heal instead of a hit. Played on defence, a ring acts as any value you need to finish a combo — but blocks nothing itself.

Riders

A rider is an extra effect bolted onto a card:

- **Fire** cards add **burn** — 1 damage a round.
- **Poison** cards add **poison** — 1 damage a round until the fight ends.
- **Ice** cards can **freeze**, and a frozen fighter misses their whole turn.

Wood cards are always plain. Riders start at bronze.



Rider cards in a battle hand

Collection, deck and copies

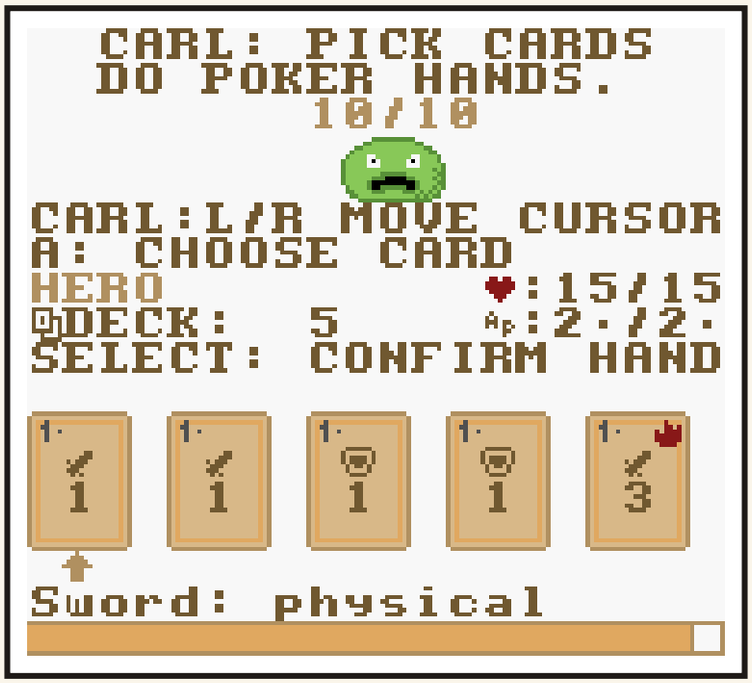
The cards you **own** are your **collection**, up to 12 different cards. The cards you **bring to battle** are your **deck**, up to 20 cards.

Open the card screen with **START**. The **DECK** tab lists everything you own; press **A** on a card to put one copy into your deck. Once every copy is decked, the next **A** takes them all out again. **SELECT** opens the card's details, and the **FILTER/SORT** row at the top of the list lets you find a card quickly.

Your deck cannot go below 5 cards. You need a full hand to fight.

7. A Battle Begins

Touch a monster and the battlefield appears. Most fights are against a **trio** of the same monster. Bosses fight alone, on their own wide screen.



The battlefield

The top of the screen shows the monsters and their health. The bottom shows you, your deck, your energy and your hand of five cards.

One round, step by step

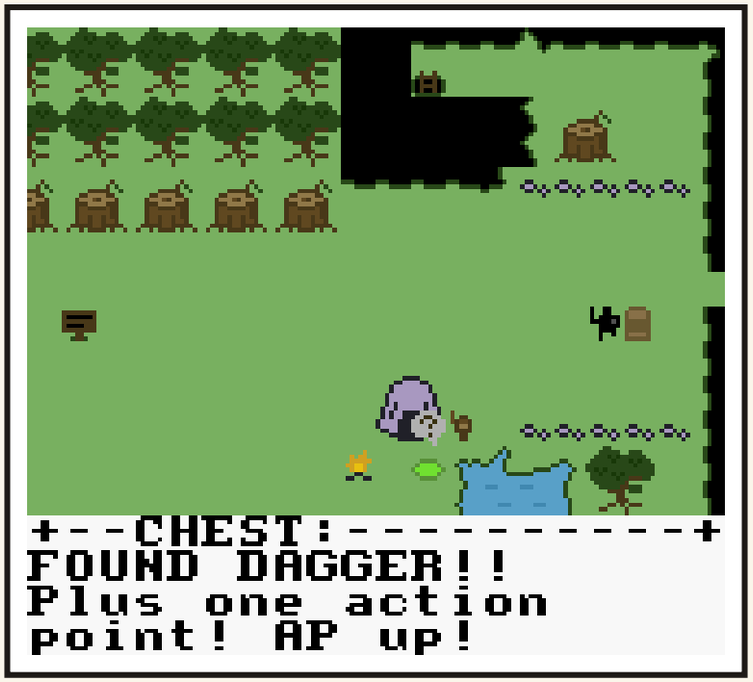
1. **Play your attack.** Pick up to five cards, then press **SELECT**.
2. **Watch it land.** Your combo deals damage or heals you.
3. **The monster shows its card.** That card's value is the damage coming at you.
4. **Defend.** Play shields to block it and press **SELECT**.
5. **Resolve, refill, next round.**

You always strike first. Keep going until the monsters — or you — run out of health.

Your hand and your energy

You draw **five cards**. Energy (AP) is what you spend to play them: **1 AP** at first, refreshed for the attack *and* again for the defence every single round.

You can raise your AP for good. The demo hides several upgrades — a practice spar, a treasure chest, a finished quest, a castle fight — each worth +1 AP a round, up to **5 AP** in total. Find them all and you will play every round at full energy.



The chest on the Field grants an action point

The timer

The bar at the bottom of the screen is a **20 second** clock. When it empties, whatever you have picked is played for you. It never runs during animations, so read the card descriptions and decide.

Attacking

Cards you pick are ranked **like a poker hand**. The better the hand, the harder the whole play hits.

Only the cards that *make* the hand count. A stray card adds nothing but still costs energy. `SW1 SW1 SW2` is a pair of ones: it hits for 2, and the `SW2` is wasted.

The **first card you pick** decides what the play does:

- Lead with a **sword, bow or dagger** and you deal damage.
- Have a **ring** anywhere in the hand and the whole play heals you instead. There is no way to deal damage and heal at the same time.
- Lead with a **shield** and you still deal the damage of the other cards; shields are harmless but they count for the combo.

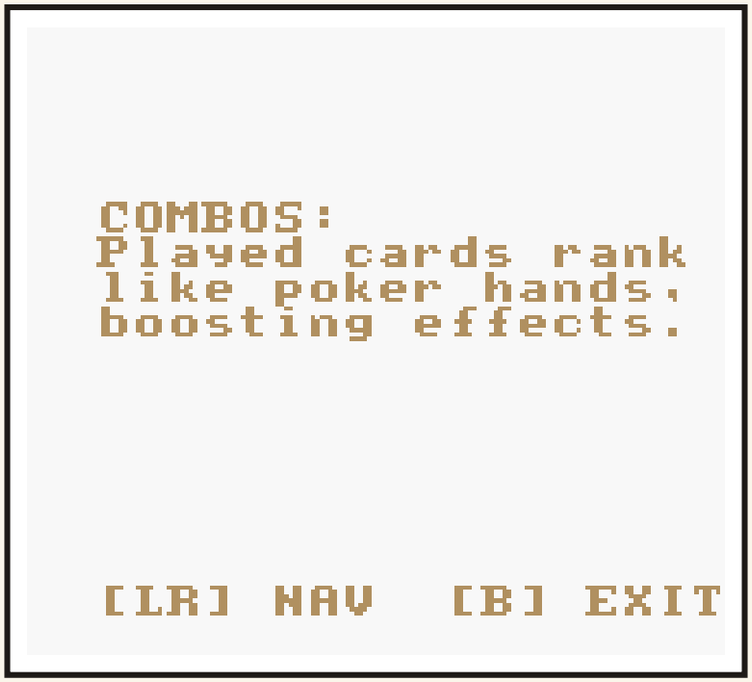
Combos: play poker!

Hand	You have	Bonus
High card	anything	100%
Pair	two of a value	120%
Two pair	two pairs	150%
Three of a kind	three of a value	180%
Straight	five in a row	210%
Flush	five of one type	240%
Full house	three plus a pair	260%
Four of a kind	four of a value	280%
Straight flush	a straight, one type	350%
Five of a kind	five of a value	400%

Five cards of the **same type** get an extra **+25%** on top, so five swords in a row hit harder than five mixed cards.

> With the **STRAIGHT GEM** equipped, three cards in a row also score. See **Gems**.

The **COMBO** row above your hand previews the tier and the damage as you pick, before you commit. Trust it.



Poker hands are the whole trick

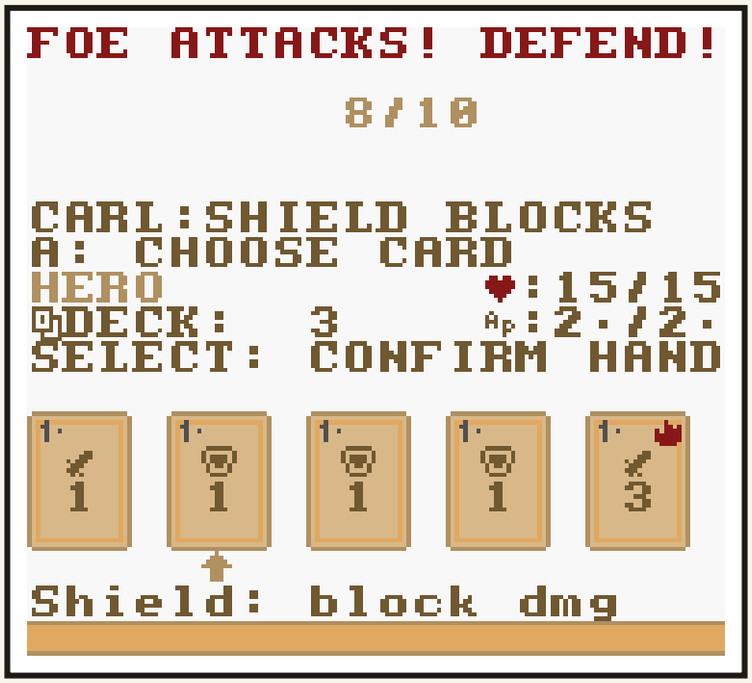
Example: `SW2 + SW2` is a pair. Base 4, times 120%, hits for **4**. Add a third `SW2` and it is three of a kind: base 6, times 180%, hits for **10**.

Defending

When the monster telegraphs its card, its value is the damage heading your way. **Only shields block.**

Damage you take is the incoming value minus the block from the shields in your poker hand. Shields outside the hand block nothing: `SH2 + SH2 + SH5` is a pair of twos and blocks 4; the `SH5` is wasted.

If your block beats the incoming damage, you take nothing — and if a **ring** is in the hand, the over-block heals you instead.



The monster telegraphs, you answer with shields

Status effects

Status	What it does
Poison	1 HP a round, greys out two of your cards
Burn	1 HP a round
Freeze	You miss your whole turn

Greyed cards cannot be picked until the poison wears off. A frozen hero skips both the attack and the block, so a freeze at the wrong moment really hurts.

Running out of cards

Every card has a number of **uses** per battle. A spent card stays in your deck but cannot be played (`OUT OF USES!`).

When the draw pile runs dry, the discards are reshuffled into it — and that round is spent doing it. The monster still attacks, so keep a shield spare.

Winning, losing, running

- **Victory:** every monster down. You earn gold, and the monster drops exactly **one card**. You choose whether to keep it, deck it, or sell it later.
- **Defeat:** your HP reaches zero. The **GAME OVER** screen sends you back to the title screen, where you can load a save — or you can stop for the day.
- **Flee:** press **B** with nothing selected during your attack. No reward, and the monster lives. You cannot flee from a defence.


VICTORY!
HERO
:15/15
DECK: 5
:0./2.
IRM HAND
YOU FOUND:
B SW
BRONZE SWORD

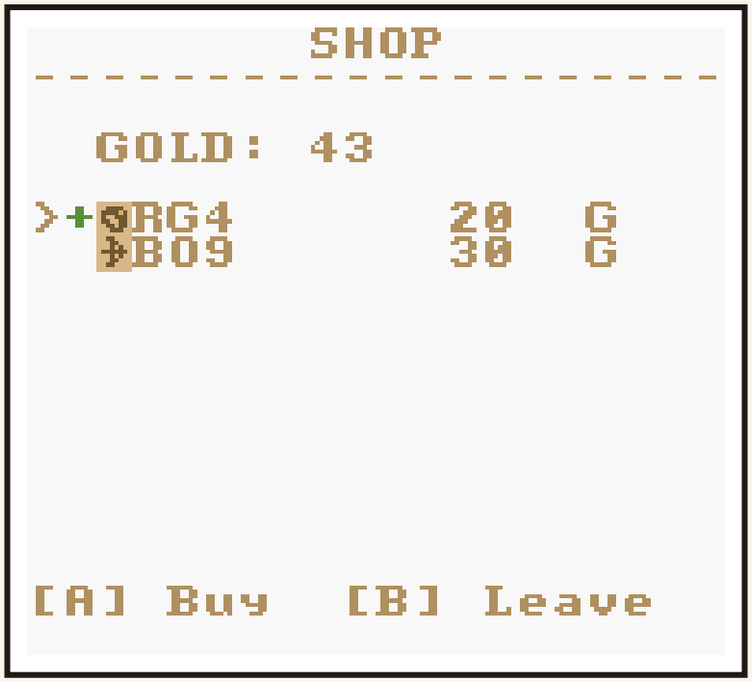
Victory

8. Gold, Shops and Loot

Battles pay in **gold** — in the demo, a slime is worth 5, a bat or a kobold 8, a spider 15. Exact rewards will vary as the game grows, but the rule holds: fighting pays, and the purse fills.

Shops open as you help people. For example, the **Merchant** opens his shop once you bring back his stolen heirloom from the north. In the demo he sells two things worth having:

- an **Iron Ring** for 20 gold — your first reliable heal,
- the **Mythril Bow** for 30 gold — the hardest single hit in the game.



The shop

On the shop screen **A** buys and **B** leaves. Press **SELECT** to switch to **SELL** mode, then pick a card to turn it into gold. Every monster drops cards, so you will always have something to sell.

> Cards are graded by material. Wood is common, bronze and iron are solid, steel is rare and mythril is the stuff of legend. Better materials drop once your AP is higher.

9. Gems

Gems are **passive skills**. They are small, permanent and a little strange: owning one does nothing at all. You have to **equip** it.

The GEM tab

Open the card screen with **START**, then move across to the **GEM** tab. Every gem you own is listed with its skill underneath its name.

- **A** switches a gem **ON** or **OFF**.
- **SELECT** opens the INFO page and explains the rules.
- You may equip at most **3 gems** at once.

An equipped gem changes the battle rules themselves, which makes gems the strongest thing you can carry. A gem you own but have not equipped is just a souvenir.

An example: the Straight Gem

The first gem in the demo is the **STRAIGHT GEM**. Its skill is **SHORT STRAIGHT**.



The chuck-a-luck table

- **Three cards in a row** now count as a combo: `SW3 DA4 SW5` scores at **130%**, slotted just above two pair.
- With a run of four, only the **best three** count. A second copy of a value scores nothing.
- **Rings fill the gaps**, because a ring can stand in for any value.
- With the gem off, the tier does not exist at all: a pair stays a pair and a high card stays a high card.

How to win a gem (in the demo)

You win it from **Nis**, a friendly kobold who runs a **chuck-a-luck** table in the village. Leave the table **20 gold or more up in one sitting** and he hands it over — once, and only once. Minigames like this are one more way the land rewards a hero; the full game will hold more of them.

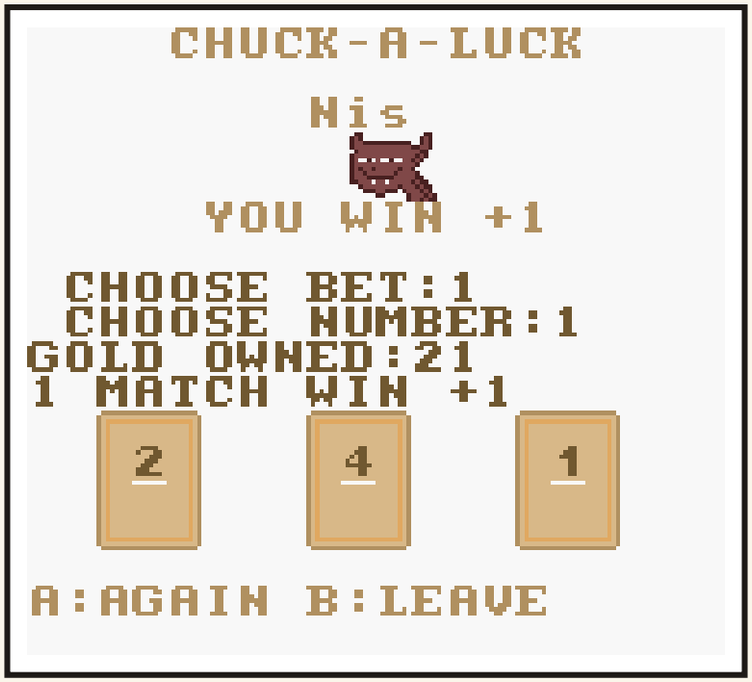
Playing chuck-a-luck

Nis's table is an early example of the minigames planned for the game.

Nis rolls three dice. You pick a number from 1 to 6 and a bet of 1, 5 or 10 gold.

Dice that match	You win
none	you lose the bet
one	1:1 — the bet back plus the bet
two	2:1 — the bet back plus double
three	3:1 — the bet back plus triple

UP and **DOWN** switch between the number and the bet. **LEFT** and **RIGHT** change the value. **A** rolls. **B** leaves the table — and that is when your sitting is counted.



The dice decide

A steady small bet is how a hero walks away up 20. Chasing a triple with big gold is how a hero walks away with a story about the time they almost won.

10. Saving and Loading

Find the **Wizard** in the settlement. He saves your adventure into one of **three slots**.



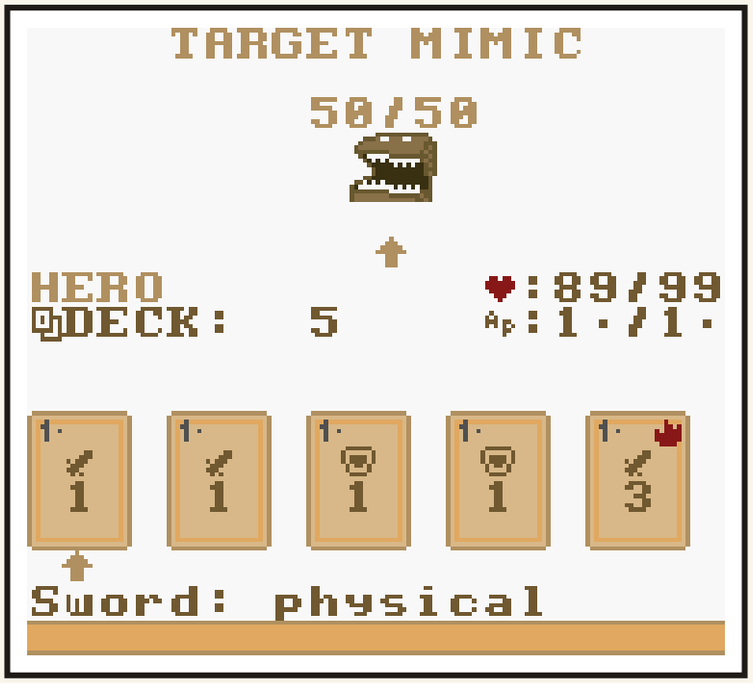
Saving the game

Choose a slot and press **A**. Your Game Boy remembers even after you switch it off, so you can always come back later.

To load, press **SELECT** while walking around, or pick **CONTINUE** on the title screen. Saving in a slot overwrites what was there before — pick a different slot if you want to keep an old adventure.

11. Winning the Demo

Defeat the **Lord of Slimes** in the castle's throne room and the demo is complete. You will see the ending, and everyone you met will have something to say about it. The full game will carry the road further.



Not every chest in the castle is a chest

If your hero falls, the **GAME OVER** screen asks:

- **YES** — return to the title screen and load a save.
- **NO** — put the Game Boy down and think about what you would do differently.

12. Tips and Tricks

- **Read the signposts.** They are honest, which is rare.
- **Only shields block.** Save them for the defence.
- **Shields still score.** A shield in your attack hand makes the combo bigger even though it deals nothing.
- **Rings are flexible.** Use one to finish a straight or a pair, or keep it for a heal.
- **Pick the lead card first.** It decides whether the play attacks or heals.
- **Watch your AP.** A bigger hand is not always a better hand when the extras score nothing.
- **Raise your AP early.** The demo hides several upgrades — spar, chest, quest, castle fight.
- **Visit the Heal Mage.** Free healing, no questions.
- **Sell cards you cannot use** and buy a good heal.
- **Save often.** You never know what is around the next corner, and now you can check.

13. Quick Reference

Starting HP	15
Starting gold	20
Starting AP	1 per phase
Maximum AP	5 per phase
Cards in hand	5
Starting deck	12 cards
Deck limit	20 cards
Collection limit	12 different cards
Decision timer	20 seconds
Gems equipped	3 at most
Save slots	3
Demo goal	Help the settlement, then head north

Now go, hero — the cards are in your hands.

14. Precautions

- Please take a short rest, ten to fifteen minutes every hour, however engrossing the slimes are.
- Stop playing and consult a grown-up if your hands or eyes start to hurt.
- Do not play in a moving vehicle. The road monsters are real.
- Wipe the cartridge with a dry cloth. Do not lick it, no matter what the kobold says.
- Save your game before switching off. The Wizard is good, but he is not that good.

This game is a work of fiction. Any resemblance to actual slimes, living or crystallised, is coincidental.

KAARTENHELD

PLAYER'S GUIDE

This booklet is the player's companion to **KAARTENHELD**, a homebrew card-duelling RPG for the Nintendo Game Boy. It was written for heroes who would rather read a page than lose a fight, and printed in the traditional pocket format: 105 millimetres square, one spot colour, small type, smaller screenshots.

If a rule in here disagrees with the game, the game is right. If the game disagrees with itself, tell the kobold.

Printed in the Grove.
Not for resale, especially to slimes.
© KAARTENHELD

